Khalistan, thereby laying the entire blame for what had happened in Punjab since 1980 solely on Sikh extremists.

Raman's glossing over of the activities of the Congress leaders involved in Op-2, made me feel that whatever he was saying should not be allowed to go unchallenged, even though it would mean criticizing my own department's white paper in front of outsiders. I also had sufficient knowledge of Sikh history as before joining the IPS in 1964, I had worked for two years as a lecturer of history at Government Ripudaman College, Nabha, Punjab. I was, therefore, conversant enough on the subject to challenge the historical contextualization that Raman was seeking to make.

No sooner had Raman finished his presentation than I stood up and said, 'Mr Raman, your white paper is full of white lies.' For a few seconds there was pin-drop silence in the auditorium. Thereafter, I started demolishing Raman's assertions one by one. About Ranjit Singh, I told him that he was one of the most secular rulers India had ever seen. He had donated the same amount of gold to the Kashi Vishwanath temple in Varanasi as he had to the Harmandir Sahib at Amritsar. He sent a special military expedition to Ghazni to retrieve the doors of the Dwarka temple which Mahmud of Ghazni had carried back as a trophy of his exploits in India. What I did not know at that time was that before his death, Ranjit Singh had also expressed a desire to offer the invaluable Kohinoor to Lord Jagannath at Puri. [4]

With reference to Raman attributing to the Sikhs ambitions of an independent state of Khalistan, I told him that barring a brief pre-Independence period, and that too due to the policy of 'divide and rule' followed by the British, there was no such demand from Sikhs in the post-independence period that I knew of. Renowned martyrs and freedom fighters such as Bhagat Singh, Udham Singh and Kartar Singh Sarabha did not give their lives for Khalistan. As a Sikh born and brought up in Punjab, I knew of only one person – other than a couple of Sikhs who held pro-Khalistan views in their personal capacity in the pre-1980 period – and that was Jagjit Singh Chauhan – who was actively propagating pro-Khalistan views. Even in his case, it was widely believed that his activities were being